

The Hitchhikers Workshop — a one-pager for a university partner

A facilitated masters-level course where the cohort trains its own local AI, writes across three forms, builds its own evaluator, and leaves holding books, papers, and verifiable provenance. This page merges the two threads the idea grew from: the air-gapped babblefish workshop, and the universities-as-partners vision from the Hitchhiker timeline sessions.

The course in one paragraph

A shared, **air-gapped local AI** (no cloud — the room's thinking never leaves the room) sits in a flight case in a seminar room. Each week the cohort writes one understanding across three tongues — **sci-fi narrative** (casting forward), **poem** (compressing to human-readable), **formal paper** — and a blind, hash-drawn gate checks the understanding *survives translation*. A different student **stewards the machine's training each week**: the model is grounded in the cohort's own consented words — audio notes, drafts, transcripts — until it is, literally, a mirror of the room. The cohort's capstone is re-fitting the evaluation harness itself: they graduate owning the examiner, not just passing it.

What students walk away with

- **Three bound artefacts** — a Book of Poems, the Collected Papers, a Story Anthology (print-ready, produced by the course's own pipeline);
- **verifiable provenance** — a hash chain proving *they* began this machine's training (every student stewards one week; every fold is signed and re-derivable offline);

- **a working evaluation harness** they amended themselves — metric, blind gate, hard constraints — a transferable research artefact;
- **consent literacy in practice** — every expression enters the corpus under a signed, withdrawable consent line (IEEE Std 7012-2025 / MyTerms — the machine-readable personal-terms standard).

Why a university — and which

The timeline vision names the partner profile precisely: **niche-research universities outside the top-tier model-aligned institutions** — departments that want sovereign compute and their own corpus, not a subscription to someone else's frontier. The course runs on one commodity machine; the department keeps the model, the corpus, and the method. Summer intensive timing ("after the universities are broken up") or a semester seminar both fit; the format is a natural node in a **"global erasmus"** knowledge- exchange — cohorts at sister institutions each train their own mage, and the *methods* federate while the *corpora* stay home.

What the institution provides / what arrives in the flight case

the university	the workshop
a seminar room, 8–14 masters students, 8–10 weekly sessions	the mage machine + carried network/naming layer (works in any room, needs no IT integration)
a faculty co-host; the grading of record	facilitation, the harness, the ceremony, the bound-book pipeline
ethics-board conversation (the consent ledger is designed to make this easy)	consent registers in three forms: plain-language, legal stub, machine-readable

Assessment posture

The course's gate answers "*does the understanding survive translation?*" — blind, replayable, third-party auditable. Marks remain the institution's own act, informed by artefacts the harness makes unusually legible: validated triptychs, fold history, each student's register contributions.

Lineage & federation

The course is the local expression of the hitchhikers.earth federation ("Proof of Understanding" is its gate too); consented outputs can federate to the community's wiki as seeds. The method's canon, engine, and audit tooling are public: github.com/mitchuski/agentprivacy-harness.

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